



BRAD GARD

KEYNOTE SPEAKER · MASTER ELECTRICIAN · TRAINING DIRECTOR, IBEW LOCAL 120

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WORKFORCE & RECRUITMENT KEYNOTE

The Trades in Crisis

THE SHORTAGE IS NOT A PIPELINE PROBLEM - IT IS A PERCEPTION PROBLEM.

THE TALK

Everyone agrees the trades are short of skilled people. Brad agrees too, and then shows why the usual diagnosis is wrong. With nine hundred applicants chasing twenty-four apprenticeship spots in his own local, the pipeline is not empty. The real question is who is in it, and who ruled themselves out years before anyone from the trade ever showed up.

He makes the case that perception hardens far earlier than high-school career fairs, that the window to change it closes around Grade 8, and that a second crisis, decades of knowledge retiring all at once, is stacking on top of the first. Then he shows what actually moved the numbers when a local stopped recruiting and started letting kids touch the real thing.

WHAT THE ROOM WALKS AWAY WITH

- **Perception, not pipeline.** Why recruiting harder just gets you more of the same.
- **The window closes early.** By sixteen, most kids are confirming, not choosing.
- **The knowledge cliff.** Enough bodies is not enough if the craft retires undocumented.
- **Access beats persuasion.** What changed participation 11.5x without a single sales pitch.
- **One kid, one door.** A concrete move every person in the room can make this year.

THE MOMENT THE ROOM GETS IT

A quiet girl who had decided this world was not for her wired a circuit, and the light came on. The grin she could not hold back is what perception change actually looks like, and why the fix has nothing to do with an ad campaign.

THE PROOF

900 Applicants for the last apprenticeship intake

24 Spots available

46% Female participation, vs a 4% industry baseline. 11.5x the average.

60% Visible minority participation

0 Safety incidents

WHAT THE ROOM SAID

Even though I realized the trades might not be for me, I still had so much fun.

ELLA, GRADE 8 STUDENT

IDEAL FOR

Industry and sector associations · Workforce and economic-development audiences · Education and school boards · Government and policy forums · Unions and apprenticeship councils

FORMATS

Signature keynote 45-60 min

Conference slot 25-30 min

Keynote + panel or Q&A 60-90 min

Brad Gard - Master Electrician & Training Director, IBEW Local 120. Builder of the one-to-one Grade 8 mentorship model. Recent keynote: NETCO, Charlevoix.

BOOK THIS KEYNOTE

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